Chalcedony, carnelian, onyx, topaz, shell, garnet, amethyst, and jasper are among them. One also encounters a similar proliferation in the usage and manufacture of beads from the wide range of stones in cities and settlements of the minerally poor middle Gangetic plains. To all such imprints of commerce and craft along old tracks, Ashoka added his own in the form of epigraphs, virtually ensuring wide dissemination of his moral worldview.

* * *

The messages began in a fairly uniform way. Promoting morality to secure worldly and otherworldly happiness would continue as the core of state policy: such happiness was not possible 'without great love of morality, careful examination, great obedience, great fear (of sin) (and) great energy.'[17] Much remained to be accomplished, he added, requiring encouragement and monitoring. The king's officials were said to be practising dhamma, and now publicly recognized as being 'able to stir up fickle (persons)'; mahamatras for people on the borders were similarly charged.[18] Implicit in the enunciation seems the acknowledgement that, given an inconstant and vacillating populace, state vigilance was a perennial requirement.

In the second edict of this set, the emperor described his dhamma as marked by 'few sins, many virtuous deeds, compassion, liberality, truthfulness (and) purity.'[19] Ways to perform virtuous deeds and be compassionate were then explained in relation to what he had himself done:

> The gift of spiritual insight has also been bestowed by me in many ways.
>
> On bipeds and quadrupeds, on birds and aquatic animals various benefits have been conferred by me, (even) to the boon of life.
>
> And many other virtuous deeds also have been performed by me.
>
> For the following purpose was this rescript of morality caused to be written by me, (viz.) in order that (men) might conform to it, and that it might be of long duration.